vanish during the recession, life was as bleak as it was for Americans caught up in the economic upheavals of the Great Depression. A lot of those people took the time to write to me, some expressing anger, others compassion and support for me. There was something I found very interesting about many of these letters: Despite the great hardships and suffering they were experiencing, many of the Americans who wrote to me expressed an optimism and faith in the future, a belief that, yes, we were living through a difficult storm, but it would pass. One twenty-seven-year-old mother of three from a small town in Oregon wrote that her husband, a construction worker, had been out of a job for over a year, their family's car had been repossessed, and they had been forced to move in with her grandparents when they couldn't pay their rent any longer. "When we thought all was lost," she wrote, "my grandparents taught us survival skills that they had learned during the Depression. We've learned the art of sewing and quilt making, we've had the pleasures of long winter nights rediscovering our family roots and growing closer; most of all, we're learning the old values, humility and independence that helped to make this country strong." Despite the hardships her family had experienced, she said she wished me well on our economic programs and the administration's efforts to cut government spending, even though it might mean more hardship. "I think it's time," she said, that "we as a country came off our high horses and got back to the business of living with pride and independence. Of living within our means. It's time we started asking, 'What does it cost?' instead of 'how much are the payments?'"

As difficult as it was, I think the period of economic hardship that began during the Carter years and continued until the economic recovery program took hold taught us something about ourselves and our country and, in the end,